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Workplace spirituality – customer engagement Nexus: the mediated role of spiritual leadership on customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors

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ABSTRACT

Customer engagement entails unequivocal frontline service employees' top performances and recommendable behaviors through management appropriate leadership to flourish. Under the social exchange and social identity theories, this study investigates employee customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors as an outcome of spiritual leadership, through the mediating effect of employee spiritual survival and well-being. PROCESS macro was used to analyze data collected from 5-star hotels full-time frontline employees in Antalya, Turkey. Results indicated that the effect of spiritual leadership on the three dimensions of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors is fully mediated by spiritual survival and spiritual well-being. Spirituality appears to be a noteworthy but remote contributor to customer engagement via employees' boundary-spanning behaviors. Our study contributed to the boundary-spanning and customer engagement literature by illustrating that a sense of mission and wellbeing at the workplace are adequate requirements to engage a frontline employee, whose boundary-spanning behaviors will be instrumental in fostering customer engagement. Further detailed theoretical and managerial implications are discussed.

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Spiritual leadership; spiritual well-being; customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors; customer engagement; social identity theory; workplace spirituality

Introduction

An ounce of prevention is worth a pound of cure.

Corporate incidents have yet again filled up the news headlines in this quinquennium, with some service organizations entangled in public relations disasters. For instance, United Airlines provoked a public outrage in April 2017 after videos of the forceful and violent removal of a passenger from an overbooked plane went viral (Laufer & Wang, 2018), causing him several injuries such as broken nose, concussion, and two lost teeth (Waldmeir & Bond, 2017), and wiping nearly US\$1 billion off the carrier's market value by the following day (Cox & Rodionova, 2017). The hotel industry was not spared either. Reported breaches of hygiene standards involved more than a dozen of five-star hotels

operating in China, including major international hotel chains such as the Waldorf Astoria, Sheraton, and Park Hyatt, where footages disclosed cleaning staff washing bathrooms mugs and cups with used towels or with same sponges and brushes used to wipe the bathtubs, toilets, sinks, and other surfaces (ABC News, 2018; Xuefei & Huiying, 2017). Understandably these incidents urged actions from authorities and forced incriminated companies into an apologetic mode, but the harm was done although it could have been prevented.

The implicit consequences of these incidents may include disappointment, dissatisfaction and abhorrence from current and potential customers, which could likely disengage them from participative actions involving value co-creation. Consumer engagement (hereafter CE) is reckoned as a strategic imperative for achieving organizations top performance (e.g. competitive advantage, sales growth, and profitability) within an intensely competitive, dynamic and interactive corporate environment (Brodie, Hollebeek, Jurić, & Ilić, 2011). As '*a customer's behavioral manifestations towards a brand or firm focus, beyond purchase, resulting from motivational drivers*' (Van Doorn et al., 2010, p. 253), CE roots itself from a frontline employee (hereafter FLE)–customer interface, whereby the customer's interaction experience with the FLE will have a significant effect on the former's level of engagement (Cambrá-Fierro, Melero-Polo, & Vázquez-Carrasco, 2014). In the light of the above mentioned recent incidents, this suggests that the process of inciting CE requires unequivocal FLEs top performances and recommendable behaviors. Undeniably too, the appropriate management leadership has a primordial role in framing their respective organization's service orientation and quality.

To this end, the present study brings forth the concept of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors (hereafter COBSBs) as a feature of nurturing customer orientation for service organizations, referring to the employees' aptitudes to display boundary-spanning roles that can tie the organization and external stakeholders (Barnes, Ponder, & Hopkins, 2015; Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Bettencourt, Brown, & MacKenzie, 2005). Three COBSBs are underlined in Bettencourt and Brown (2003) and Bettencourt et al. (2005) work: *service delivery*, *internal influence* and *external representation*, the first being more role-prescribed while the others are more extra-role. Research has shown that these COBSBs are fructified with greater organizational justice and perceived organizational support (Bettencourt et al., 2005; Trybou, De Caluwé, Verleye, Gemmel, & Annemans, 2015), but precluded by role conflict and role ambiguity (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003). Due to their relevance in linking service industry firms to actual and potential customers, several scholars have paid attention to this matter. However, a review of the literature discloses non-negligible gaps.

First, recent boundary-spanning related studies with empirical foci examined employee's perceptions of role ambiguity/conflict (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003), justice (Bettencourt et al., 2005), occupational undermining (Yoo, 2013), job-related training, rewards and empowerment (Lee, Nam, Park, & Ah Lee, 2006), and affect (Barnes et al., 2015). Psychological phenomena or cognitive structures that are conducive of and inherent to an employee customer-oriented performance and prosocial behaviors have received little attention from research, although the role of FLEs' COBSBs seems quite critical in reinforcing actual customers' engagement and promoting the organization to potential ones. In this regard, scholars (Korschun, 2015; Yoo, 2013) have called for a further investigation of this issue.

Second, nascent studies on spiritual leadership (hereafter SL) have evidenced it as fueling intrinsic and transcendental motivation of employee, so as to enhance their performance and fulfill their life satisfaction, and were respectively conducted in the service industries such as healthcare (Hunsaker, 2016; Sani, Soetjipto, & Maharani, 2016; Yang, 2017; Yang, Liu, Wang, & Zhang, 2017), education (Kaya, 2015; Markow & Klenke, 2005; Wong, Mahmud, & Omar, 2015), telecommunication (Wahid & Mustamil, 2017), financial institutions (Afsar, Badir, & Kiani, 2016; Norman, 2017) just to list few. A focus on the heavily customer-dependent and highly competitive tourism and hospitality industry has been ignored, to the notable exception of Salehzadeh, Khazaei Pool, Kia Lashaki, Dolati, and Balouei Jamkhaneh (2015). This industry is competition intensive because the trend in the 21st century has shifted toward customers seeking more quality experience and relaxation moments (Yu, Byun, & Lee, 2014), and failure in delivering such services will see any hotel losing its customers to competitors.

Third, research has shown that spiritually led employees exhibit greater positive individual/organizational-related attitudes and performances (Chen & Yang, 2012; Fry, Vitucci, & Cedillo, 2005; Wahid & Mustamil, 2017). SL (Fry, 2003, 2016) implies an intrinsic motivation and inspiration of employees through a transcend vision and a corporate culture of altruistic love, resulting in the followers' sense of *calling* (purpose, meaning and difference-making of their life) and *membership* (feeling of belonging, understood and appreciated). With modern workplaces characterized by anxiety, pressure, exhaustion and work overload (Chen & Yang, 2012), employees and supervisors are reduced to mechanical occupational life. However, research regarding any leadership role on FLEs customer-oriented outcomes is scarce. Notwithstanding the study of Lee et al. (2006) that investigated the effect of empowerment and Yoo (2013) that examined perceived undermining on role-prescribed/extra-role performance (COBSBs), the managerial influence perspective in this regard has been widely overlooked, or prosocial behaviors as outcomes were limited to organizational citizenship behaviors and attitudes.

Thus, grounding on social exchange and social identity theories, the aim of this study is to develop and test a model that investigate the effect of spiritual leadership on employee-customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors (COBSBs) characterized by *service delivery* (role-prescribed), *internalized influence* and *external representations* (extra-role) (Betten-court et al., 2005). Furthermore, the mediating effect of employee spiritual survival (calling) and well-being (membership) on the proposed model will also be examined. Accordingly, the present study's contributions to the body of knowledge are fourfold. It advances the service marketing/management, specifically the boundary-spanning and customer engagement literature by showing the importance of cognitive and factors psychological in motivating employee COBSBs, behaviors which can strengthen the foundation of a customer level of engagement. In other words, a sense of mission and wellbeing at the workplace are adequate requirements to engage a FLE whose boundary-spanning behaviors will be instrumental in fostering CE. Our study additionally contributes to the hospitality and growing SL literature in testing for the first time a model of SL on hotel FLEs. It shows that spirituality greatly contributes to frame motivational drivers that carve hotel employees service orientation and involvement.

Furthermore, this study also advances the social exchange and social identity theories literature by articulating the COBSBs as an employee positive and reciprocal response to his/her organizational identification initiated by the supervisor SL goal motivation

(transcendental vision and hope/faith) and values dissemination (altruistic love). Specifically, the evidence express that the self-concept identification to the relational alter ego's concept and the relational exchange setting is imperative to embolden the fallouts of the relationship. In other words, our study complements the social identification theory to the social exchange theory to highlight an implicit mechanism that governs frames the orientation and magnitude of an exchange relationship.

Practically, this study addresses service and specifically hospitality industry managers' perspectives reconsiderations. Sustaining competitive advantage in a dynamic environment is the Holy Grail any aspiring leading service firm manager seeks. Accordingly, CE is an unequivocal core tacit resource an organization can rely on to expand its value. To that end, it is imperative for managers to redefine and redesign their strategies that stress their customers' level of engagement by rethinking the role of their boundary-spanning employees. Thus this study suggests them to rethink their strategic human resource management tactics by setting their FLEs into more integrative and participatory functions that can make them get the best from their employees' boundary-spanning role.

Background and hypotheses development

Workplace spirituality

Workplace spirituality has gained importance as from the 1990s, and increasing attention from researchers (Madison & Kellermanns, 2013). Among several reasons for the surge of spirituality at the workplace, there are terrorist attacks, and employees' demoralization due to a vacillating economic situation influencing increasing downsizings; but the most important one found is that people spend more and more of their energy and time at work than in their community (Garcia-Zamor, 2003). Consequently, their workplace has become a principal base for their spirituality supply (Fairholm, 1998; Fry, 2003; Geh & Tan, 2009; Madison & Kellermanns, 2013).

Goertzen and Barbutto (2001) categorized spirituality into beliefs in the sacred, unity and transformation, and Smith and Rayment (2007, p. 220) later defined it as '*a state or experience that can provide individuals with direction or meaning, or provide feelings of understanding, support, inner wholeness or connectedness*'. In other words, spirituality is a metaphysical and metacognitive drive which leads and gives sense to one's life in his environment and beyond the simple interactional links with other people. The implied transcendence of spirituality and its corollaries on beliefs greatly contributes to blurring the line separating spirituality 'secular' approach and religion's 'sectarian' one (Hill & Smith, 2003). This line represents the common ground both spirituality and religion share: a sacred core, a sense of meaning and altruism (Fry, 2003; Hill, Jurkiewicz, Giacalone, & Fry, 2013; Hill & Smith, 2003). The sacred core reflects the sacred dimension of life – or something related to it – for which its sanctity quality provides some transcendental experience (Hill & Smith, 2003); the sense of meaning depicts the formulation of a purpose that gives a sense of worthiness, importance and meaningfulness to existence (Hill et al., 2013); altruistic love is the devotion and esteem to others' interest (Fry, 2003).

Due to these similarities and overlapping identities, spirituality is sometimes mistakenly confounded with religion, and it is therefore imperative to stress on their dichotomous difference. On the one hand, religion refers to a structure of ritual prayers and teaching

of dogma, alongside with acceptance of and faith in claims of one tradition and existence of a form of heaven (Dalai Lama, 1999). Religious groups are usually driven within the framework of doctrines and prescribed tenets that shape the code of conduct and behaviors to be observed by its members (considered as sinful beings) in order to reach the path to God and salvation (Benefiel, Fry, & Geigle, 2014; Fry, 2003; Zellars & Perrewé, 2003). Furthermore, religion can promote arrogant views that a particular group may be worthier or superior to others, leading to the exclusion of those not sharing in similar denominational traditions (Benefiel et al., 2014; Cavanaugh, 1999).

On the other hand, spirituality is instead referred to the inner qualities of the human spirit (e.g. love and compassion, sense of harmony and responsibility), a spiritual quest characterized by a perpetual process of one's voluntary discovery of his or her full potential or seek for transcendence, and a personal connection with a supranatural force or being (Ayoun, Rowe, & Yassine, 2015; Ayranci & Semercioz, 2011; Dalai Lama, 1999; Zellars & Perrewé, 2003). Moreover, Koenig, McCullough, and Larson (2001) articulated specific dualities between spirituality and religion. They noted that in contrast to religion, spirituality is more individualistic – in the intrinsic sense of the term – focused, implicit, subjective, inwardly directed and emotionally oriented, and less quantifiable, systematic, authoritarian, formal, stresses unity and harmony than doctrine, and has slight external accountability (Hill & Smith, 2003). As such, the development of spiritual inner qualities is uncontingent on religion or similar metaphysical belief system (Dalai Lama, 1999; Fry, 2003).

Ashmos and Duchon's (2000) widely accepted definition of workplace spirituality articulates it as '... the recognition that employees have an inner life that nourishes and is nourished by meaningful work that takes place in the context of community' (p. 137). In this sense, involved in workplace spirituality is one's effort in finding own ultimate purpose in life, developing a strong connection with colleagues and relevant work stakeholders, as well as having congruence between one's core beliefs and the organizational values (Milliman, Czaplewski, & Ferguson, 2003). Several dimension of workplace spirituality have been articulated in the literature, but the core premises originated from Ashmos and Duchon's (2000) framework include the following: inner life and meaningful and purposeful work, sense of community, and values congruence with the organization's (Houghton, Neck, & Krishnakumar, 2016; Milliman et al., 2003). Inner life refers to the level of spirituality of an employee and how his/her internal spiritual needs are brought into the workplace (Houghton et al., 2016). Meaningful work relates to the employee job that gives personal meaning and is aligned with a higher order purpose and overall value (Houghton et al., 2016; Milliman et al., 2003). The sense of community refers to the notion that employees seek to be in communion with co-workers through mutual obligations, sharing, and commitment, as well as feeling integrated into a community and its activities (Houghton et al., 2016; Milliman et al., 2003). Finally, values congruence with the organization is the extent of self-identification and connectedness with the organization values, mission, and goals (Gupta, Kumar, & Singh, 2014; Milliman et al., 2003).

An employee seeking for spirituality at work in an organization promoting it, thrives better in his/her professional life and is more efficient and productive, because spiritually healthy organizations develop more compelling and purposeful vision, which then stimulate members' experience of deeper level of consciousness, encourage teamwork, improve intuitive skills and boost innovation (White Jr, 2003). Such circumstances may be profitable to the organization regarding competitive advantage (Mitroff & Denton, 2012) and appeal

managers' interest because the non-adoption of changes related to spiritual orientation may lead to the organization's failure in the shift to the learning echelon prevalent in the 21st century (Fry, 2003). Henceforth, leadership appears to be a mean in incorporating spirituality values and management practices (Madison & Kellermanns, 2013). Precisely, leaders must be integrated into their followers' needs of spiritual survival translated by membership and calling via an articulated vision and fundamental values such as charity, humility, and veracity of service to followers and relevant stakeholders (Fry, 2003).

To date, the most relevant model of leadership that consistently incorporates and addresses the critical issues of workplace spirituality, and contributes in advancing empirical research on workplace spirituality with critical implication on theory, research, and practice of leadership is Fry (2003; Fry et al., 2005) spiritual leadership theory (Benefiel et al., 2014; Hill et al., 2013; Houghton et al., 2016). Spiritual leadership, therefore, bridges the facets of workplace spirituality and spiritual survival within an intrinsic motivation model underpinning (Benefiel et al., 2014; Fry, 2003), to incorporate fundamental behaviors, attitudes, and values for an intrinsic self and others' motivation. This, in turn, will encourage a sense of spiritual survival and well-being through calling and membership (Fry, 2003; Fry et al., 2005; Hill et al., 2013) and ultimately individual and organizational level work outcomes.

Spiritual leadership

Fry's (2003) theory of spiritual leadership is drawn primarily from motivational-based paradigms like transformational and charismatic leadership, that foster and underscore intrinsic motivation and follower transcendence (Anderson & Sun, 2015; Chen, Yang, & Li, 2012). SL is a causal leadership theory drawn for organizational transformation that is designed to create an intrinsically motivated, learning organization (Fry et al., 2005; Fry & Whittington, 2005a, 2005b). Fry et al. (2005) refer to SL as the attitudes, values, and behaviors that a person must endorse to intrinsically motivate self and others so that, both have a feeling of a definite increase in spiritual survival and well-being through a sense of calling and membership. That is, they have a sense of making a difference, experience meaning in their lives, and feel understood and appreciated (p. 836).

A spiritual leader's features embody: (i) a vision which is a *'picture of the future with some implicit or explicit commentary on why people should strive to create that future'* (Kotter, 1996, p. 68), and entails the organizational reason and, most prominently, its future; (ii) an altruistic love which is the characteristics of both followers and leaders in having a sense of harmony, completeness, cheerful feelings, and well-being developed through genuine attention, care, and appreciation for both self and others (Fry, 2003; Fry & Cohen, 2009); and finally (iii) hope and faith defined as *'the source for the conviction that the organization's vision, purpose, or mission will be fulfilled'* (Fry, 2003, p. 713) such that everyone in the organization know and are confident with the way and the path to follow to meet the organization mission and are ready against any constraints or difficulties (Fry & Cohen, 2009). Specifically, a spiritual leader should have the consciousness and understanding of self and also for others, be intuitive, and be driven by a robust sense of advanced purpose, love, and stewardship. Moreover, SL stresses on the interconnectedness between the leader and the followers, stimulated by an operating mode based on love and not fear, as well as a clear and visionary orientation to the future while appreciating the present (Altman, 2010).

Customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors

COBSBs are to prosocial behaviors that FLEs demonstrate with the aim to link their organization to its customers/stakeholders. More specific to service firm employees, there are three dimensions of COBSBs (Bettencourt et al., 2005; Bettencourt & Brown, 2003). (i) *Service delivery*: the responsive, courteous, flexible and conscientious mannered service delivery from which customer satisfaction highly depends on. (ii) *Internal influence*: the individual initiative taking in communicating with the firm and colleagues to improve self, colleagues and the organization service delivery. Their boundary spanning role allows them to record changes in customers' needs and appropriate service delivery and share this information internally. (iii) *External representations*: the vocal promotion and advocacy of the firm's image, products, and service to outsiders. Employees play a salient role in representing their organization by polishing its legitimacy and its services to external stakeholders. Bettencourt et al. (2005) indicated that these three COBSBs exist on a continuum of role prescribed versus extra-role behaviors. Service delivery, for instance, is more role-prescribed because it is recurrently indicated in job descriptions, training and performance evaluations. Internal influence and external representations are more discretionary behaviors that are more on the extra-role end of the continuum. They are subject to the employee appreciation and willingness and not formally indicated by the job description.

Hypotheses development

Theoretical foundations

The social exchange and social identity theories provide the theoretical underpinning of our research model. The social exchange theory (hereafter SET) is amid the most prominent workplace behavior explaining conceptual paradigms (Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). It proposes that a series of mutual exchanges between two parties empower the quality of their relationship, resulting in productive and beneficial behaviors (Blau, 1964; Mitchell, Cropanzano, & Quisenberry, 2012). In the workplace context, economic exchanges relationships are mostly contractual and stem from formal agreements that indicate the rewards to expect under role expectations (Bettencourt et al., 2005). The exchanges can also include more than transactions of benefits between the employer and the employee and involve interpersonal attachments referred to as social exchange relationship). In this case, when the employer genuinely 'takes care' of his employees, this stimulates favorable outcomes such as employee positive work attitude and productive work behavior (Blau, 1964; Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005).

The social identity theory (hereafter SIT) proposes that an individual defines him-/herself and others into different social categories like organizational membership or affiliation, and this identification is the perception of oneness with or belongingness to a group which involves direct or mediated experience of the group failure and success (Ashforth & Mael, 1989; Tajfel & Turner, 1986). The factors reinforcing one's identification to a group, initially affiliated to group formation, include among others shared goals or threats, proximity, similarity, interpersonal interactions, and they generally ensue into selflessness, collaboration and intragroup cohesion (success (Ashforth & Mael, 1989). In the organizational context, an employee strong identification with the organization manifests itself by the former embracing the values, goals, history, challenges and opportunities of the latter

in a way that s/he appropriates the group success and failure as his/hers, and engages in organizational citizenship behaviors (Korschun, 2015).

Spiritual leadership and spiritual survival

Fry and his colleagues (2005, 2003) argue that, in an intrinsically motivated environment with individuals having attained a sense of spiritual survival and well-being, the vision driven by the leader stimulates the followers to feel a sense of calling where they believe in the meaning of their life and that they make a difference. Calling refers to the feeling of transcendence one experiences, i.e. how s/he perceives making a difference through serving others. Such feelings derive in the sense of meaning and purpose in life (Hannah, Walumba, & Fry, 2011). This means that leader or follower believes in the worth and indispensability of their respective profession to the society and consequently are proud to belong to the occupation group they are in.

Furthermore, being within an organizational culture enhancing altruistic love, genuine care for other fuels a sense of membership, where each and everyone feels understood and appreciated (Chen & Li, 2013; Fry, 2003; Fry et al., 2005). The fundamental assumption of Fry and his colleagues' model is that loving and caring leaders believing in their organization mission will create together with their followers an environment with principles and values, peace and harmony. In response to the leader attributes, followers will experience spiritual survival and well-being. Consistent with Fry et al. (2005) framework, Wong et al. (2015) and Chen et al. (2012) studies conducted in other industries, we propose that a manager genuinely exhibiting SL attribute will trigger in their employees feeling of meaningfulness, purpose, and universal value of their job, and nurture an organizational culture of care where each employee will care of others and will feel included and fully part of the organization. Thus, the following hypotheses are proposed:

H1: Spiritual leadership characterized by altruistic love, hope/faith, and vision will positively influence employees' spiritual survival sense of (a) meaning/calling and (b) membership

Spiritual leadership and COBSBs

An employee prosocial behavior also springs from the quality of the interaction and relationship s/he develops with the supervisor (the internal organization representative by extension), the colleagues, the customers or suppliers (Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). In fact, the SET theory posits that these relationships have repercussions on the behavior in a way that when an employee reckons the helpfulness, support, and love s/he receives from the employer, s/he acts in a manner of reciprocity through positive work attitude and productive work behavior. In this respect, a spiritual leader instills in a subordinate the motivation to achieve sets of goals through a transcendental vision; inspires the conviction of the employee that the goals will be met regardless of potential challenges through hope/faith; and through altruistic love, creates a work atmosphere defined by completeness, harmony, cheerful feelings, and well-being whereby care, genuine attention, and appreciation for both self and others are primordial.

In such circumstances, the employee may in goodwill adopt prosocial behaviors that are aimed at matching the implicit resources that the supervisor has exchanged with

him/her. Thus s/he may display COBSBs that are role-prescribed (*service delivery*), but also and mostly discretionary/extra-role (*internalized influence* and *external representation*). S/he will likely deliver a flawless service to customers in line with the motivation and conviction of meeting the organization mission, will engage in exchanging critical information to the peers and superiors that may enhance the team or company performance, and ultimately positively refer the organization and its products/services to customers and other external stakeholders. Bettencourt et al. (2005) suggested the development of social exchange relationships with service employees as the cornerstone for a customer-oriented climate and assimilated COBSBs to prosocial behaviors such as organizational citizenship behavior (OCB).

Several studies have evidenced the direct relationship between SL and prosocial behaviors such as OCB (Chen & Li, 2013; Kaya, 2015; Madison & Kellermanns, 2013) and heightened job performance and/or productivity (Chen & Li, 2015; Salehzadeh et al., 2015) in service organizations which is in line with SET. Similarly, they found that spiritual leadership positively affected employees' sense of altruism, consciousness, and courtesy which are discretionary attitudes directed towards colleagues and the organization, and productivity which represents an effective work behavior and is more role-prescribed. Research on SL and boundary-spanning behavior being scarce, we propose that in line with previous literature on SL and prosocial behaviors, SL will influence employee COBSBs, hence the following hypothesis.

H2: Spiritual leadership positively influences an employee COBSBs, namely (a) external representation, (b) internalized influence and (c) service delivery.

Mediating effect of spiritual survival/well-being

An employee spiritual survival/well-being, characterized by a sense of calling and membership, represents the idiosyncratic processes that make the employee feel valuable in that, s/he believes to be worthy of something and can make a difference in the society, but also feel appreciated and understood by the colleagues, and belonging to a team, department or an organization as a whole. From the attributes of the spiritual leader, an employee will feel embedded in or affiliated to a group that acknowledges, cherishes and respects him/her, and that can eventually intensify the motivation to achieve something or 'make a difference' in line with the organization mission. In fact, the values congruence assumed by SL between leaders and followers is critical in framing the social identity of organizational participants. The perceive membership or affiliation to the organization's goals is likely to drive the positive employee behavior according to the SIT (Tajfel & Turner, 1986). In this respect, identifying self with the organization in the sense that an employee assimilates his/her self-concept with the organization and vice-versa, can ultimately lead to an appropriation of the company's positive/negative results, and as noted by Korschun (2015) be crucial in the boundary-spanning context.

Further in his framework of meeting employee engagement with external stakeholder under the lens of SIT, Korschun (2015) pointed out that the stronger the employee organizational identification, the more salient is the perceived boundary between the employee and external stakeholders such that the relationship becomes '*more adversarial than cooperative*' (p. 2). Yet, the SIT proposes that organizational identification operates in

tandem with the content of the organizational identity and the perceived organizational (non-)membership. Therefore, should the stakeholder being reckoned as a member by an employee, and the organizational identity orientation deemed corporative, the outcome of organizational identification will be alleviated or inverted (Korschun, 2015). This last articulation merges two philosophies. First, service firms tend to associate customers and local communities as members of their 'family,' and design policies prescribing employees friendliness vis-à-vis customers. Such orientations are aimed at retaining current customers, attracting potential ones, and display an immaculate corporate image. Second, the spiritual leadership framework advocates a corporate environment that put forth love and related caring-wise values. Eventually, the effect of this leader's attribute on employee spiritual well-being is likely to spill over onto the employee surrounding such as the professional, social and family interface.

An employee that feels embodied and appreciated in the organization and has a transcendental need of achieving goals (through the lenses of the institution) can strongly self-identify to that organization, and as fallout, will feel compelled to behave and act in a way that benefits the firm. Motivated employees tend to work harder to excel due to their satisfaction in performing a task (Yoo, Arnold, & L, & Frankwick, 2014). In this vein, a service employee perception of making a difference through serving others (sense of *calling*) and belonging to an acknowledging, appreciative and loving organization (sense of *membership*) will likely accentuate the service delivery performance to customers in the most impeccable fashion. It may also stimulate the said employee's voluntarily helpfulness and encouragements vis-à-vis colleagues (Yoo et al., 2014) so as to maintain high standard service performance. Similarly, identification to the organization can yield further discretionary behaviors such as advocacy and representativeness. The more an employee identifies to the company, the more s/he will likely promote, defend, and voluntarily represent the company.

Previous studies have investigated the effect of employee spiritual survival/well-being on prosocial behaviors and work attitudes in various service industries such as retail service and financial service (Chen et al., 2012; Chen & Li, 2013; Chen & Yang, 2012; Yoo et al., 2014), healthcare (Geraci, 2016; Hunsaker, 2016; Yang, 2017), education (Kaya, 2015) and lodging industry (Salehzadeh et al., 2015). Specifically, links between calling and membership and OCB (Chen & Li, 2013; Chen & Yang, 2012; Hunsaker, 2016; Kaya, 2015; Madison & Kellermanns, 2013) were revealed. These scholars found that calling and membership positively related to the dimensions of OCB such as OCB toward individual and organization, characterized by altruism, conscientiousness, sportsmanship, courtesy, and civic virtue. Other studies (Chen et al., 2012; Fry et al., 2005; Salehzadeh et al., 2015; Wahid & Mustamil, 2017; Yang, 2017) found that calling and membership are positive inducing factors of service employee performance and productivity. In Yoo et al.'s (2014) study employee achievement-striving motivation, which referred to the conviction and desire to perform tasks, positively affected boundary-spanning behaviors.

In this paper, we propose that supervisor SL attributes will drive a service employee COBSBs through spiritual survival/well-being. Precisely, altruistic love, hope/faith, and vision that make a manager leadership style will be salient to employee role-prescribed and discretionary behaviors when the employee is affected by these characteristics. In other words, the attributes of and values championed by SL first will ignite the subordinate sense of meaningfulness and difference-making motivation, establish a workplace

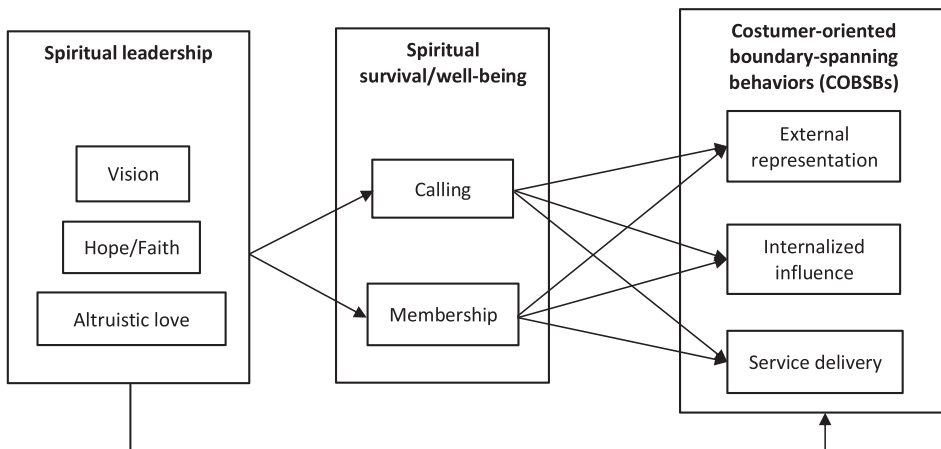


Figure 1. Research model.

atmosphere diffusing love, care, compassion and solidarity for self and others so that one feel appreciated and belonging to the group. Note that these attributes of the SL framework connect with the core premises of workplace spirituality discussed above (meaningful work, sense of community, and congruence with organizational values). Subsequently, this will reinforce the employee identification to the firm that can encourage him/her in voluntarily engaging in COBSBs in two ways: as a positive attitude and response vis-à-vis the nature of the interpersonal relationship with the supervisor, but also as an ambassador of the organization s/he identifies to that will use all possible resources to link the organization and its customers. That is, the three dimensions of the COBSBs namely *service delivery*, *internalized influence*, and *external representation* would be the mirrored outcome of an attained work meaningfulness, a felt sense of community as well as a self-appropriation of organizational values. In this light, we propose the following hypotheses. **Figure 1.**

H3: Calling positively influences an employee COBSBs, namely (a) external representation, (b) internalized influence and (c) service delivery.

H4: Membership positively influences an employee COBSBs, namely (a) external representation, (b) internalized influence and (c) service delivery.

H5: Calling mediates the positive impact of SL on (a) external representation, (b) internalized influence and (c) service delivery.

H6: Membership mediates the positive impact of SL on (a) external representation, (b) internalized influence and (c) service delivery.

Methodology

Sampling and data collection procedure

With nearly 6 million international visitors in 2016 (TMCT, 2017), the province of Antalya in Turkey is the second most visited province in Turkey after Istanbul. Its location on the

country's southwestern Mediterranean coastline endows it with mild winters and hot and dry summers (Woosnam, Erul, & Ribeiro, 2017). As of June 2017, Antalya accounted for nearly half of the 5-stars hotels in Turkey with 340 out of 685 certified facilities (TMCT, 2017), hence justifying the research scope. Moreover, the focus on 5-stars hotels is because first they supposedly lead regarding proficient management, and second, they tend to employ more personnel than other facilities, therefore providing more representative perceptions and thoughts of employees about their organization. The study population consisted of full-time frontline employees because first frontline staffs directly interact with, and consistently partake in their satisfaction, loyalty, and engagement; second, full-time personnel are usually spared from the industry seasonality constrictions than part-time employees and thus have a greater span work-life experience within the organization.

The research team received approval from 14 hotels' Management to collect data from their FLEs. Self-administered questionnaires were distributed over two weeks-lagged periods, time I and time II. Each respondent was assigned a code, to match time I and time II questionnaires. Also, cover letter and sealable envelopes were given to the participants to ensure anonymity and confidentiality. The time I instrument included COBSBs scale and demographic profile items. Time II instrument included spiritual leadership scale. Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, and Podsakoff (2003) suggested implementing such practices to control for potential common method bias threats. The instruments were translated from English into Turkish, and then back to English (Sperber, 2004) by two subject-matter expert academicians fluent in both languages. A pilot study with 20 hotel fulltime FLEs was conducted prior to the main study, and no modification was deemed essential from the results obtained. 350 questionnaires were distributed at time I and 309 were retrieved. At time II 309 questionnaires were redistributed, and 250 responses were used after deletion of unusable and incomplete questionnaires. The final sample consisted of 66.4% of male, 67.6% were aged 18–29 years, 75.6% had three years or less of job tenure, and nearly 75% had completed high school level. These results are comparable to those of other studies in the same location (Arslaner & Boylu, 2017; Burke, Koyuncu, Fiksenbaum, & Tekin, 2013).

Measures

All the instruments were retrieved from the existing literature. The spiritual leadership scale was adopted from Fry et al. (2005) and includes 26 items nested into five subscales and assessed using 5-point Likert-type anchors (strongly disagree to strongly agree). Staffs' COBSBs were assessed with the scale developed by Bettencourt et al. (2005) that measures service delivery with 5 items, internal influence and external representation with both 4 items.

Analysis

The statistical analyses were executed using SPSS 23.0 and AMOS 23.0. First, a CFA was performed to scrutinize the measurement model quality, namely the model fit, convergent and discriminant validity. Second, the SPSS PROCESS macro (Hayes, 2013) was utilized to conduct the path analysis of the proposed model. Prior data analysis, the skewness and

kurtosis of the variables' distribution were examined and all value fell within the range -2 – 2 (George & Mallery, 2010), suggesting normality of the distribution.

Results

Measurement model

The results of the CFA showed that the model fit the data well: $\chi^2(530) = 694.73$, $p = .000$; $\chi^2/df = 1.31$; CFI = .963; IFI = .964; TLI = .959; RMSEA = .035; SRMR = .043. Additionally, a CFA was carried to investigate the existence of a second-order factor for the SL three dimensions. Marsh and Hocevar (1985) suggested that a comparative coefficient of a second-order model chi-square ratio to the first-order model chi-square ratio approaching 1 justifies the use of the second-order factor. The fit indices for both first- and second-order model of SL were identical: $\chi^2(74) = 120.07$, $p < .001$; $\chi^2/df = 1.62$; CFI = .975; IFI = .964; TLI = .969; RMSEA = .05; SRMR = .03. The comparative coefficient ($120.07/120.07$) equaled 1 (Anderson & Gerbing, 1988; Marsh & Hocevar, 1985) suggesting the use of the second-order factor of SL for hypotheses testing. Fornell and Larcker's (1981) criteria were considered to assess the convergent and discriminant validity. Standardized factor loadings (FL), composite reliability (CR), internal consistency (α) and average variance extracted (AVE) of all constructs are presented in Table 1. Except for one item of internalized influence and three of altruistic love, all other items consistently loaded onto their respective latent construct. CR and Cronbach's α values exceeded the threshold of .70, and all AVEs were above .50. In Table 2, the square roots of each variable AVE were greater than the intercorrelations between all other variables. In all, this provided support for convergent and discriminant validity.

Hypotheses testing

Before running PROCESS model 4, Vision, hope/faith and altruistic love were averaged beforehand to form spiritual leadership (SL) the predictor variable and the results and conclusions are exhaustively presented in Table 3. All the hypothesized direct effects were supported at $p < .0001$, namely H1 (a and b), H2 (a, b and c), H3 (a, b and c), and H4 (a, b and c). Moreover, H5 and H6 (a, b and c) respectively proposed a mediating effect of calling and membership on the 3 dimensions of COBSBs. A 95% bias-corrected and accelerated confidence interval (BCa CI) bootstrap with 10,000 resamples provided the statistical significance of the tested indirect effects. As presented in Table 3 too, all the direct paths (c') turned insignificant in the presence of the mediators and significant indirect effects, indicating full mediation effects and thus providing full support for H5 and H6.

In addition, the magnitude of the indirect effects was scrutinized through the variance accounted for (VAF) with is the indirect-to-total effect ratio. Specifically, calling and membership cumulatively explained 102.95% of the effect of SL on internalized influence, 87.97% on external representation, and 68.33% on service delivery. Furthermore, the differences between the two specific indirect effects on the three COBSBs dimension were found statistically insignificant as their respective confidence interval did not contain any zero. This means that none of the mediators was found significantly greater than the other in explaining the variance in the three outcomes.

Table 1. Indicators factors loadings and constructs reliability.

	FL	CR	α	AVE
<i>External representation</i>		0.86	0.85	0.599
ext_rep1	0.828			
ext_rep2	0.821			
ext_rep3	0.761			
ext_rep4	0.675			
<i>Internalized influence</i>		0.80	0.80	0.567
inter_1	0.781			
inter_2	0.769			
inter_3	0.706			
inter_4	–			
<i>Service delivery</i>		0.85	0.85	0.526
delivery1	0.794			
delivery2	0.796			
delivery3	0.697			
delivery4	0.644			
delivery5	0.684			
<i>Sense of membership</i>		0.85	0.85	0.531
memb1	0.652			
memb2	0.69			
memb3	0.77			
memb4	0.824			
memb5	0.693			
<i>Sense of calling</i>		0.81	0.81	0.514
call1	0.72			
call2	0.71			
call3	0.722			
call4	0.717			
<i>Vision</i>		0.91	0.91	0.674
vision1	0.839			
vision2	0.841			
vision3	0.838			
vision4	0.751			
vision5	0.833			
<i>Hope/Faith</i>		0.86	0.86	0.558
hope1	0.781			
hope2	0.712			
hope3	0.739			
hope4	0.758			
hope5	0.742			
<i>Altruistic love</i>		0.78	0.78	0.501
altrust1	0.659			
altrust2	–			
altrust3	–			
altrust4	0.732			
altrust5	0.71			
altrust6	0.658			
altrust7	–			

Note: (–) items dropped during the CFA

Discussion

The paramount aim of this study was to propose and test the influence of spiritual leadership on employee customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors via spiritual survival (calling) and spiritual well-being (membership). Our findings reveal that spiritual leadership has a significant positive effect on frontline employee's customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors, and this is fully mediated by calling and membership. These results substantiate the idea that spiritual leadership, through value alignment between leader and subordinates, accentuates spiritual well-being and subsequently heightens

Table 2. Intercorrelations and discriminant validity criterion.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Vision	0.821							
2. Hope/Faith	.570**	0.747						
3. Altruistic love	.522**	.564**	0.708					
4. Calling	.382**	.485**	.536**	0.717				
5. Member	.415**	.441**	.470**	.572**	0.728			
6. External Representation	.314**	.318**	.360**	.526**	.535**	0.774		
7. Internalized Influence	.254**	.289**	.313**	.505**	.505**	.552**	0.753	
8. Service Delivery	.280**	.392**	.371**	.479**	.491**	.516**	.514**	0.726

** . Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed). Figures on the diagonal represent the AVEs square roots.

positive individual outcomes (Benefiel et al., 2014). The finding provides some advancement to the extant body of knowledge as discussed hereafter.

Implication for theory

First, the study contributes to the hospitality and burgeoning spiritual leadership literature in testing for the first time a model of spiritual leadership on hotel frontline employees, whose service performance has a salient upshot on customers and subsequently the organization (Tian, Song, Kwan, & Li, 2018). Research validating spiritual leadership has overwhelmingly overlooked the hospitality industry, with the notable exception of Salehzadeh et al.'s (2015) study with hotel middle managers. The first set of hypotheses proposed the positive influence of spiritual leadership on employee sense of calling and membership, and results indicated that it has a strong effect on both variables, with the effect on calling slightly stronger than membership's. This suggests that an employee intrinsically motivated by the conviction and belief that a clearly articulated vision can be attained, within a working environment characterized by genuine care and appreciation of others, will indeed instill a feeling of the job role as a transcendental mission that gives a meaning to his/her life while feeling accepted and acknowledged by the peers. These results are comparable with other studies (e.g. Fry, Latham, Clinebell, & Krahne, 2017; Salehzadeh et al., 2015), and addresses the importance of spirituality in the hospitality industry. More specifically, hotel frontline employees are subject to a relational pluralism involving interactions with different stakeholders (Shipilov, Gulati, Kilduff, Li, & Tsai, 2014) such as customers, colleagues, and supervisors, which can be challenging in the case of difficulty, uncooperativeness or partiality of the relevant stakeholders. This plurality of interaction and other experienced issues such as low remuneration, extended working time (Lee, 2016), customers verbal aggression (Karatepe, Yorganci, & Haktanir, 2009) have the potential to prompt undesirable outcomes such as emotional exhaustion, disengagement, withdrawal, and likely service sabotage and job incivility (Kao, Cheng, Kuo, & Huang, 2014). In this regard, a spiritually driven workplace stressing value congruence between supervisor and employee, and fostering caring reciprocity environment backing up the fulfillment of a higher order mission, provides the premises for an employee's intrinsically motivated sense of transcendental purpose, meaningfulness and feeling of belongingness. These can act as positive levers that boost employee morale, heightened self-efficacy, and promote relentless motivation to perform the job while relatively overlooking instrumental sources of stress and dissatisfaction that prevail in a highly demanding environment.

Table 3. Multiple mediation analysis results.

	β	SE	t	p		Conclusion
a_1 – SL → Calling	.574	.0565	10.161	.000	$R^2 = .3163, F(5,244) =$	H1a: supported
a_2 – SL → Membership	.537	.0592	9.064	.000	22.575, $p = .000$	H1b: supported
<i>Criterion: External representation</i>					$R^2 = .3166, F(5,244) =$	H2a: supported
c – SL → ER	.480	.0752	6.381	.000	22.608, $p = .000$	H3a: supported
b_1 – Calling → ER	.404	.0815	4.953	.000	$R^2 = .1964, F(5,244) =$	H4a: supported
b_2 – Membership → ER	.355	.0777	4.567	.000	11.923, $p = .000$	
c' – SL → ER	.058	.0820	.704	.482	$R^2 = .3872, F(7,242) =$	
					21.847, $p = .000$	
<i>Indirect effects</i>	Coeff.	Boot SE	95% BCa CI		VAF	
(M1) SL → Calling → ER	.232	.0567	.131	.358	48.27%	H5a: supported (Full med.)
(M2) SL → Membership → ER	.191	.0557	.095	.315	39.70%	H6a: supported (Full med.)
M1 – M2	.041	.0851	-.123	.212		
<i>Criterion: Internalized influence</i>	β	SE	t	p		
c – SL → II	.405	.0748	5.406	.000	$R^2 = .1220, F(5,244) =$	H2b: supported
b_1 – Calling → II	.374	.0812	4.603	.000	6.7800, $p = .000$	H3b: supported
b_2 – Membership → II	.376	.0774	4.858	.000	$R^2 = .3285, F(7,242) =$	H4b: supported
c' – SL → II	-.012	.0817	-.146	.884	16.914, $p = .000$	
<i>Indirect effects</i>	Coeff.	Boot SE	95% BCa CI		VAF	
(M1) SL → Calling → II	.214	.0574	.115	.341	53.03%	H5b: supported (Full med.)
(M2) SL → Membership → II	.202	.0507	.113	.313	49.92%	H6b: supported (Full med.)
M1 – M2	.013	.0809	-.141	.178		
<i>Criterion: Service delivery</i>	β	SE	t	p		
c – SL → SD	.481	.0700	6.867	.000	$R^2 = .1786, F(5,244) =$	H2c: supported
b_1 – Calling → SD	.283	.0793	3.569	.000	10.611, $p = .000$	H3c: supported
b_2 – Membership → SD	.309	.0756	4.098	.000	$R^2 = .3168, F(7,242) =$	H4c: supported
c' – SL → SD	.152	.0797	1.910	.057	16.033, $p = .000$	
<i>Indirect effects</i>	Coeff.	Boot SE	95% BCa CI		VAF	
(M1) SL → Calling → SD	.162	.0508	.073	.270	33.76%	H5c: supported (Full med.)
(M2) SL → Membership → SD	.166	.0474	.085	.270	34.57%	H6c: supported (Full med.)
M1 – M2	-.004	.0708	-.142	.138		

Second, our study extends the service marketing/management, specifically the boundary-spanning and customer engagement literature by examining for the first time employee COBSBs within the framework of a spiritual leadership model under the lens of social exchange theory. Previous investigations have overlooked this stream of research, particularly in the hospitality industry. We hypothesized and found support for the positive influence of spiritual leadership on employee COBSBs. Precisely, spiritual leadership positively affected service delivery, external representation, and internalized influence. The effect on the later and the explained variance was marginally lower than those of the first two. These findings are consistent with the tenet of reciprocity articulated by social exchange theory (Blau, 1964) that employee behaviors are the repercussion of the quality of the relationship with the supervisor. Specifically, a manager providing (implicit but valuable) resources such as love, purpose and instilled conviction in the relationship with an employee will likely cast out positive work attitudes and behaviors from him/her, in response to the privileged and particular nature of their relationship.

Our findings suggest that an employee will display prosocial work-related behaviors as a result of the interaction with a spiritually leading management. Such caring practices and behaviors from the management through the supervisor can develop a positive emotional bond between the employee, the supervisor and the organization that explains the employee prosocial behaviors vis-à-vis the team and the company. The results of this study are analogous to previous literature in the leadership–prosocial behavior research field. For instance, recent empirical findings evidenced the positive effect of ethical leadership on employee customer-oriented citizenship behavior (Garba, Babalola, & Guo, 2018) and extra-role performance (Tu & Lu, 2016), servant leadership on extra-role behaviors (Panaccio, Henderson, Liden, Wayne, & Cao, 2015) and customer-oriented OCB (Wu, Tse, Fu, Kwan, & Liu, 2013), while Zehir, Müceldili, Altındağ, Şehitoğlu, and Zehir (2014) indicated that authentic leadership positively affected employees OCB. In this respect, the implications for the organization are threefold. First, the employee consistently performs the role-prescribed tasks and duties consciously and professionally. Second, s/he will voluntarily get involved inside the organization and provide information or help to maximize fluid and efficient work processes and sound service quality. Third, s/he will benevolently represent and advocate for the organization where and when necessary.

We also hypothesized within the framework of workplace social identity theory and found empirical ground that calling and membership positively predict the three COBSBs dimensions. Specifically, regarding the magnitude, the effect of calling was the strongest on external representation followed by internalized influence and service delivery, whereas the effect of membership was more pronounced on internalized influence followed by external representation and service delivery. Also, calling and membership equally predicted internalized influence. However, calling had a stronger effect on external representation than membership, while for service delivery the impact of membership was greater. The sense of calling and membership is inherent to employee assimilation of the self-concept to the organization's and vice versa, in that the feeling of belongingness to the team/group/company catalyzes the fusion of the organization's objectives (vision) with the employee perception of transcendental purpose. Accordingly, the employee will tend to embrace the fate and performance of the organization by enacting a strong congruence with the stakeholders (Korschun, 2015) and display decent behaviors that benefit to colleagues, customers, and other external stakeholders. These findings

underscore the prominence of cognitive and psychological factors in motivating employee COBSBs. Specifically, individual attachment and identification, as well as a sense of purpose, are prominent drivers of customer-oriented behaviors in their most integrative scope as formulated by the COBSBs. Employees' emotional embeddedness to the organization and perceived transcendental purpose of the job seem to account for greater variances in extra-role than role-prescribed behaviors due to intrinsic motivational drivers. This concurs with studies suggesting that sense of calling is strongly relevant to critical organizational and individual outcomes, such as knowledge sharing with organization members and service quality (Lee, 2014, 2016), and extra-role behaviors (Caillier, 2016).

Our findings finally illustrated that the effect of spiritual leadership on the three dimensions of COBSBs was fully mediated by calling and membership. In other words, the spiritual leadership impact on internalized influence, service delivery, and external representation is only determined by the employee sense of calling and membership. In fact, these results suggest that spiritual leadership effect on COBSBs will be manifest if and only if on the one hand it significantly stimulates an intrinsically motivated need of achievement and fulfillment on the follower, and on the other hand establish a working environment that sparks genuine care, appreciation, and love that can seal an emotional attachment of the follower to the group. This will in turn prompt and galvanize one's endeavors to exhibit prosocial behaviors such as COBSBs. The theoretical underpinning proposed in this study provides a follow-up to Bettencourt et al.'s (2005) assumption that social exchange theory does not offer the only explanation of COBSBs regarding FLEs and the organization. Precisely, we have assumed the workplace SIT's articulation that an employee identification is revealed by an embodiment of the organization's values, goals, history, challenges, and opportunities, in a way that the employee appropriates the group's success/failure experience as his/hers, and thus engages in some form of organizational citizenship behaviors (Korschun, 2015).

Although a social exchange relationship between leaders and followers provides the framework for the leveraging effect of SL on employee service performance and prosocial behaviors, it is the follower's identification to the organization that enhances and consolidates this effect. Initially, however, value congruence in meaning and difference-making between leader and followers, and altruistic love-based organizational climate stimulating feelings of being appreciated and understood assumed by SL are essential to initiate the said organizational identification. This may explain why idiosyncratic patterns such as cognitive structures (sense of calling, meaning/purpose) and psychological factors (emotional tie from the sense of membership/belonging) fully account for the effect of SL on employee COBSBs. Our findings are also consistent with those of previous similar studies. For instance, Caillier (2016) hypothesized a partial mediation of mission valence on the relationship between transformational leadership and employee extra-role behaviors, but instead found a full mediating effect; Madison and Kellermanns (2013) study revealed that employees' fulfillment of spiritual needs fully mediated the positive influence of spiritual leader on OCB. In line with previous literature on spiritual leadership (e.g. Fry et al., 2017; Yang & Fry, 2018), we argue that the positive (or negative) effects of intrinsic motivation instilling leadership attributes on individual, team and organizational positive (or negative) outcomes, are contingent on followers' achievement of higher order or spiritual needs, which have the potential to fully unlock desirable job attitudes and behaviors while dampening negative ones.

In a nutshell, an overwhelming majority of the CE literature is centered on Van Doorn et al.'s (2010) conceptualization by underscoring – and rightfully so – customer-based components as significant antecedents such as *perceived service quality*, *interaction*, *attention* (So, King, Sparks, & Wang, 2016), *emotion* and *satisfaction* (Pansari & Kumar, 2017), *company identification* and *relationship quality* (Romero, 2017), *service quality* via *perceived value*, *brand image*, and *customer satisfaction* (Hapsari, Clemes, & Dean, 2017). An understudied but critical domain of building CE, relating to the service firms, it yet to received adequate attention. Vivek, Beatty, and Morgan (2012, p. 137) noted that '*there is a great opportunity for organizations to engage existing or potential customers by supporting customer-initiated engagement*,' highlighting the active play organizations should undertake. A recent multilevel study (Chen, Weng, & Huang, 2018) demonstrated that sales representatives' integrity and the quality of the relationship with a customer were significant predictors of CE. To that end, considering FLEs relevance in linking service industry firms to actual and potential customers, this study projects their COBSBs as instrumental in engaging actual, potential, or non-customers, by meticulous service delivery performances towards actual customers, diligent internal influence within the firm in vehiculating critical information that can enhance service performances, and actively representing the organization externally towards other stakeholders. This sets a landmark for further research linking boundary-spanning roles and CE.

Managerial implications

Spirituality at the workplace has become a tremendously salient topic because it entails individual compassion, personal achievement of transcendental objectives that are needed in the 21st century learning-oriented organizations (Madison & Kellermanns, 2013). It seems to be particularly of interest to executives to implement it in their management practices. Managers, in the service industry and in the hospitality industry more precisely, are confronted with high turnover which comes with associated costs. The results of this study suggest them that in such a tense and demanding occupational setting, employees should be motivated and genuinely assured of the transcendental importance of their position to sustain their intrinsic motivation of achieving something meaningful, and also work in an environment where they feel appreciated not only for the mere transactional exchange of service for remuneration. Spiritual leadership appears to be the tool merging spirituality and management that top management can apply in the organization policies and training.

Second, employees COBSBs are relatively analogous to organizational citizenship behavior regarding altruism beyond formal expectations. These are assets of social capital that can be handy for an organization in outperforming its competitors. Thus, it is of best interest for managers to invest in such assets for their organization. Because frontline employees with strong COBSBs will deliver an impeccable service experience to the visitors, will proactively perform their duties and efficiently communicate with colleagues on crucial information about the workflow and service. This can even be maximized if an employee is spiritually motivated in achieving a meaningful job and feel embraced by the organization. The present research proposes to managers seeking for dedicated, thoughtful and tenured employee a solution in investing in their employees' COBSBs as social capital of the organization.

In this vein, spiritually led and fulfilled frontline employees' dedicated service delivery and internalized influence materialized among others by sharing and disseminating critical information, altruism, and initiative taking can have the potential to encourage an innovative culture at the organization/team level and innovative service behaviors at the individual level. Innovative service organizations are prone to greater rents and revenues than competitors, which are generated by their business performance and business image that springs from the way or manner customer sees and patronizes a business, its products, and services (Bayighomog, Shamout, Harazneh, & Abubakar, 2018). Hence service industry organizations' top management executives are better off integrating within their corporate strategies policies implementing and nurturing their employees COBSBs through spiritual fulfillment, as these behaviors can contribute to the organization's core competencies and capabilities.

Last but not least, customer engagement can be consistently addressed with employees COBSBs. Specifically, a frontline employee that delivers a compelling and delightful service experience to the customer while uncondescendingly advocating and 'marketing' the assets of the facility, for instance, will likely trigger the visitor's interest and approval, and further positive word-of-mouth and recommendations to friends and relatives. Managers should see in COBSBs an asset that maximizes their organization brand value, and implement policies that foster and nurture these behaviors to attain optimized their customer engagement and get a substantial competitive edge over other protagonists.

Future studies

The social exchange and identification theory contend that the nature and quality of the relationship and the magnitude of the social identification are subject to time. This study articulated a model examined on cross-sectional research design and de facto, could not accurately estimate the temporal causal effect of spiritual leadership on COBSBs after attaining spiritual survival/well-being. Future research should conduct longitudinal studies in this manner. For instance, they could examine these effects from newly hired employees and follow them up over several periods. Second, self-reported measurement of personal performance is likely to be consistently biased from the rater. As a remedy to another limitation of our study, we suggest that the rating of COBSBs dimension of service delivery should be done by a direct supervisor who overlooks the employee performance and is likely to give less biased responses than the focal employee if self-rated. Third, our sample consisted of only fulltime-frontline employees of 5-star hotels. It was relatively medium to low considering the number of such hotels available within the scope of our research, and conducting a data collection during the winter period when the touristic activities generally drop did not help either. We recommend to use more extensive and representative samples, but also to compare the findings with lower stars hotel and other types of hospitality facility. Finally, the study proposed that the relationship between SL and employee COBSBs reflects a social exchange taking place between leaders and followers; Future studies may also examine this directly through perceived organizational or supervisor support, as well as person-organization fit. Such endeavor would shed a comprehensive light on the effect proposed by this model from different theoretical perspectives and across different strata of the hospitality industry.

Conclusion

The present study developed and tested a model investigating the mediating effect of employee sense of calling and membership on the positive effect of spiritual leadership on the three dimensions of COBSBs. With supportive evidence of full mediation, the results have contributed to advance the spiritual leadership theory by testing for the first time a spiritual leadership and COBSBs model on hotels FLEs. FLEs in the hospitality industry plays a critical role in customers' formulation of positive first impressions from initial contact, a delight from irreproachable service performance, and recommendable opinion about the organization from external stakeholders. The study also projected FLEs COBSBs as a potential facilitator of CE due to their proximity between the current and potential customer and forefront ambassadors of the company. Thus, a more scrutinized attention from top executives downstream to frontline managers is needed to address the spiritual well-being of organizational members that will result in recommendable sets of behaviors, with a particular emphasis on the principal actors – FLEs – of the link between the organization and customers. Such endeavor can provide undisputable premises to customer engagement across all strata of the service industry.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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